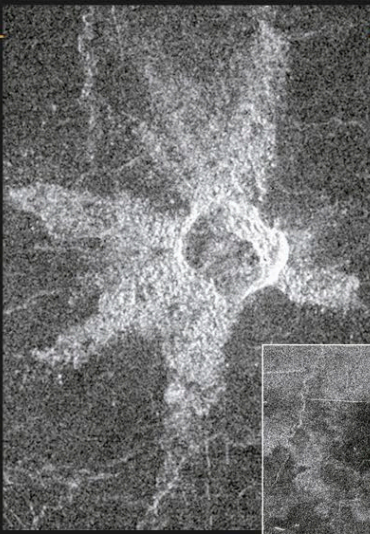
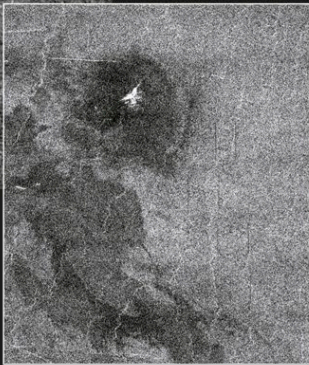




UNUSUAL CRATER

This small crater, about 4 miles (6 km) across, has terraced walls and lobes of ejecta radiating out from the rim to give it an unusual starfishlike appearance.



DARK HALO

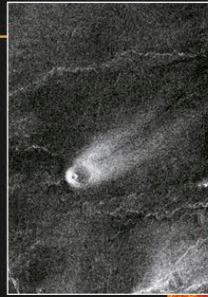
A dark halo surrounds a bright feature that appears to be a cluster of small impacts, ejecta, and debris formed by an impactor that broke up in the atmosphere.

IMPACT CRATERS

Although many hundreds of impact craters have been identified on Venus, this total is low compared to that for the Moon and Mercury. There were more craters in the past, but they were wiped out by resurfacing due to volcanic activity about 500 million years ago. Venus's craters have some characteristics not seen elsewhere in the solar

system, because its dense atmosphere and high temperature affect the incoming impactor and crater ejecta. Ejecta can, for example, be blown by winds and form fluidlike flows. And some potential impactors are too small to reach the surface intact. They break up in the atmosphere and either a resultant shock wave pulverizes the surface or a blanket of fine material formed

by the breakup produces a dark halo mark before a crater forms. Wind has also modified the surface, creating wind streaks and what may be sand dunes.



WIND STREAK

A 22-mile (35-km) long tail of material has been created on the northeast side of this small volcano by prevailing winds.



WIND EROSION

Impact debris thrown 300 miles (500 km) to the northeast of Mead Crater has been modified by surface winds. Wind streaks are visible, but it is not known if these are bright streaks on dark terrain or vice versa.

GEOGRAPHY

Present maps of Venus are based on data collected by the Magellan probe (see panel, opposite), with additional information from previous missions. The coloring of the maps below and Magellan images is based on the colors recorded by Venera 13 and 14.

The orange color is due to the atmosphere filtering out the blue light. The following terminology is used for the surface features: lowland plains are termed planitia; high plains, planum; extensive landmasses, terra; mountain ranges, montes; and mountains or volcanoes, mons. A chasma is a deep, elongated, steep-sided depression. The features are all named after women, both historical and mythological, with the exception of Maxwell Montes (see p.120).

TOPOGRAPHIC MAP

This relief map, based on Magellan data, covers the surface about 16° on either side of the equator and between 152 and 217° east. The highest ground is shown as red and the lowest ground as blue. A complex system of troughs snakes through the highland region named Aphrodite Terra.

